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Tales from Frick Park IV: They have a mouth and must not scream

Bertie Wooster
387.44 Million Miles of Hate

“Alright everyone, if we could gather in a semicircle—yes, perfect—watch your step there. Welcome to Carnegie Mellon University! My name is Victor and I’ll be your tour guide today.

Behind me you’ll see one of our most iconic landmarks: Walking to the Sky. Feel free to take a photo, just no flash. Sudden stimuli can ... interfere with the finish.”

Everyone squints upwards. “Yes, it is quite tall. The sculpture represents aspiration, forward motion, the limitless potential of CMYou.”

A faint, papery crack as one of the figures shifts almost imperceptibly.

“That lifelike texture is intentional,” Victor continues lightly. “The artist wanted to evoke the immediacy of the human form.”

Another pause. A student at the back raises a hand. “Did—did that one just blink?”

Victor smiles. “Great question! CMU is interdisciplinary. What you’re seeing is the result of a collaboration between the School of Art and the Robotics Institute.”

The wind carries something down from above. A sound, thin and strained, almost a word.

A mother tilts her head. “It sounded like—”

“—wind through structural elements,” says Victor smoothly. “Totally normal. Each figure is selected to remind them of their

commitment to campus life.”

The lowest figure’s jaw trembles. The paint at the corners of its mouth has cracked, revealing something damp beneath the lacquer.

Victor steps slightly to his left, blocking the view. “Fun fact: our retention rate is among the highest in the nation. This is because some students become such a vital part of the Carnegie Mellon community they’re invited to join it permanently.”

Another eerie noise, this time a soft moaning, reminiscent of a sob.

“We do ask that all participants refrain from vocalization during tour hours,” Victor announces, louder now. “This ensures we don’t disrupt visiting families or negatively affect yield.”

A drop of something dark hits the pavement. Victor’s sneaker slides over it. “Just preservative. They’re selected posthumously, of course. Lab accidents, shuttle crashes, food poisoning. We honor our fallen with our Robotics Institute’s pioneering neural reanimation.”

A student lowers his phone. “So they’re zom—”

“Yes, they’re legacy students.” This joke is greeted by faces almost as lifeless as those above.

“Isn’t it inspiring,” he continues, “how still they are? That level of professional polish is something you’ll develop here.”

“Anyways, we’ll be heading to the Cohon University Center next. And remember: at Carnegie Mellon University, our heart is in the work.”

Background

Apex’s dominance had become unbearable. Worthington’s revolutionary wheel geometry made every other team look slow, and his refusal to explain his design had pushed CIA and SDC to their limits.^[3] A previous attempt to discuss the design during the 2025 Spring Carnival was abandoned when Worthington laughed for 45 seconds as he made “Apex more like Gaypex” jokes.^[4]

Formation of alliance

The breakthrough came when a CIA operative and an SDC operative found themselves hiding behind the same ad hoc PVC cart outside the Apex workshop at 4 AM (the average waking time of a buggy mechanic, per prior intelligence). They turned to talking about what their surveillance was for and it turned out both SDC and CIA’s engineering teams had developed precision delivery systems and were scoping out a bombing run. They spent two weeks arguing about whose was better before realizing they could just use both, which engineers from both sides spent a subsequent week integrating the two (this consisted of duct-taping them together in a Doherty Hall classroom).^[5]

Intelligence gathering

Worthington’s patterns were alarmingly predictable. Each morning at 05:00, he emerged from his garage—which contained a cot, 3 whiteboards covered in incomprehensible scrawls, and a \$4,500 La Marzocco espresso machine funded through the team’s discretionary materials budget—to perform his traditional pre-dawn practice victory lap.^[6]

The lap consisted of walking slowly around Flagstaff Hill exactly once, accompanied by his drivers, which Worthington believed made their course routes better, but which surveillance teams described as “just a few people walking in a circle, like, one time, slowly.”^[7]

Operation

At 05:00 on 28 February, Worthington emerged for his victory lap. At 05:43, he returned to the garage and began preparing his first espresso of the day. At 05:47, four modified commercial quadcopters, two from each team, approached from opposite directions.^[8] Witnesses reported seeing the drones pause momentarily in mid-air as they passed each other, as if acknowledging the historic nature of their collaboration, before continuing to their target.^[9]

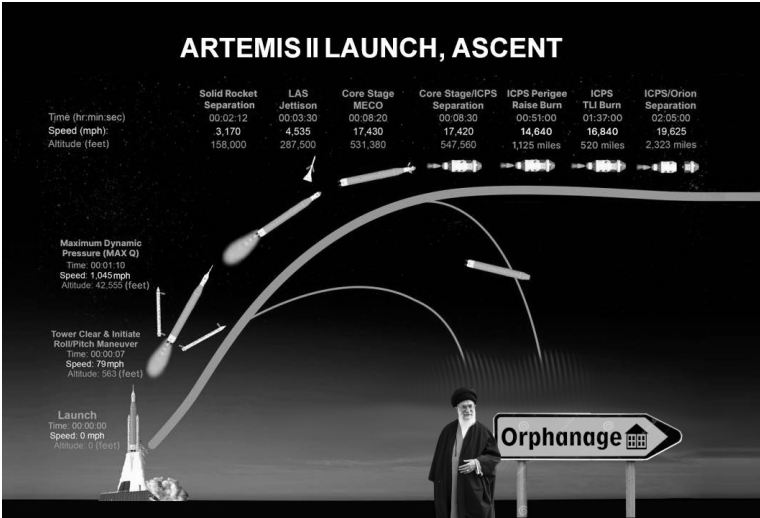
All four drones simultaneously released their payloads. The espresso machine was destroyed beyond recognition. Worthington, his executive assistant (a role created specifically to bring him coffee), his lead mechanic, and three first-year recruits who had been sleeping in the bunker were all terminated.^[10]

Aftermath

Members of CIA and SDC celebrated together at Revolution Noodle.^[11] The handshake they had practiced was, according to observers, “longer than necessary” and “a little try-hard,” but everyone involved seemed satisfied.^[12]

The Sweepstakes Committee released a statement expressing “concern” and reminding teams of “the importance of a safe practice environment,” which all parties interpreted as meaning they had no idea what to do and hoped everyone would just calm down.^[13]

Apex, meanwhile, held an emergency meeting to determine who, if anyone, understood the remains of Worthington’s whiteboards. The answer, it emerged, was no one.^[14]



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HANK GREEN's

BA presents...

*brother is coming
to town!*

Student
Tickets
Ran Out!
Sorry :(

*vlogbrothers
star and Crash
Course co-
founder*

7:00pm

Carnegie Music Hall

April 10, 2026

*There is no guarantee that Hank will
show up at his brother's event

